

Baseball Gained Interest Steadily as Spirit of Era Rose to Pinnacle

By CLELL BUZZELL

After Doubleday may have invented baseball back in 1839, but it wasn't yet the national pastime in Eau Claire in 1872. The Cincinnati Red Stockings had just become the first all-professional team (1869).

But Eau Claire had a baseball game as early as 1882 when the East Side Lone Stars played the West Side Crocodiles.

In the 1890's, a Baseball Association incorporated for \$5,000 to buy and fence a 300 by 600 foot lot on the west side for a baseball park.

In the 1890's, Eau Claire had a team playing league ball. Interest in baseball was growing steadily as newspapers began to cover play in the National League.

By the turn of the century, baseball was fast becoming America's national pastime. The emergence of the American League to rival the National, their short-lived feud and agreement which set up the first World Series in 1903 served to focus public interest on the game.

It was an era without radio and television. But baseball results were eagerly followed in the newspapers and such names as Connie Mack, Clark Griffith, Frank Chance, Honus Wagner and Ty Cobb were becoming well known.

By 1910, Eau Claire had a team — the Commissioners — playing daily in the Wisconsin-Minnesota League with rivals from Wausau, La Crosse, Superior, Duluth, Rochester and Red Wing. In that season, Russ Bailey, Eau Claire's first big star, rejoined the city team after playing with Milwaukee of the American Association.

World War I put a damper on baseball in the next decade. But then came the roaring '20's when major league baseball approached its zenith of the Babe Ruth

- Lou Gehrig - Lefty Grove - Mickey Cochrane era.

Eau Claire had a city team — the Moose — playing home games at the Driving Park off Farwell St. in 1924. The pitcher was Art Johnson and another star was Marty Smith.

The 1930's brought the Great Depression. But in the depth of that economic disaster began Eau Claire's 30-year venture in pro ball — the Eau Claire Bears and the Northern League.

With former Chicago White Sox star Johnny Mostil as manager and Dave Quinn footing the bills, the Bears opened in 1933 at seat-less Chappel Field near the Delta Pond. It was a struggle to keep the team going in its early years.

The Bears in 1938 moved to the new Carson Park baseball field built as an anti-depression project with federal funds. Its lighted field enabled the club to play night games and helped boost attendance.

Herman D. White of Eau Claire was elected Northern League president in 1935 — on a temporary basis to keep the circuit from folding. It proved to be a 5-year term lasting until 1940 during which White made the league outstanding in the nation and became one of the most respected executives in all baseball.

World War II cut back baseball in half of the 1940 decade but set the stage for its golden era in the following years. Fans flocked to Carson Park in the late 1940's and early 1950's to watch such stars as Bill Britton, Henry Aaron, Orlando Cepeda, and Frank Gravino playing under such managers as Andy Cohen, Bill Adair, Charley Fox and Earl Weaver.

Fifteen Sign for Auxiliary Charter Here

An American Legion Auxiliary unit was organized in Eau Claire in the latter part of 1920 and received its official charter April 4, 1921.

Fifteen women signed the application for the charter filed by Mrs. H.C. Vermilyea. Mrs. Vermilyea had been requested by Commander Victor Slotz of the Wm. C. Johnson Post 53 of the American Legion in Eau Claire to "see what she could do about getting an auxiliary unit started in the city."

First officers of the unit were: Mrs. Vermilyea, president; Mrs. Frank E. Wilson, vice president; Mrs. Bailey Ramsdell, secretary; Miss Mae Hill, treasurer; Miss Gladys Bye, historian; and the Rev. F. E. Wilson, chaplain.

Membership today stands at 300, which includes mothers, wives, sisters, daughters and granddaughters of Legion members or deceased veterans.

Officers of the unit are Mrs. Leonard Kewin, president; Mrs. Mildred Haskins, 1st vice president; Mrs. Marion Tubbs, 2nd vice president; Mrs. Josephine Nohring, secretary; Miss Diane Nelson, treasurer; Mrs. James Bremer, historian; and Mrs. Ina King, chaplain.

Disposing of Sewage Big Problem for City

Sewage disposal was one of Eau Claire's main problems in 1935. A survey was made at that time and a 10-year plan was under consideration. All the city's sewers emptied into both rivers.

Street Car Tracks Removed Here in 1931

The old street car tracks and ties in the 3rd Ward and on the north side of Eau Claire were removed and the streets repaired in 1931. Paving of Hy. 12 from Eau Claire to Fall Creek was also completed.

Miracle Braves

Eau Claire fans joined thousands throughout the state and Midwest to help write the miracle story of the Milwaukee Braves, who for seven straight years from 1953 through 1959 drew more than 1,500,000 to County Stadium, topped by a record 2,515,404 in 1957. They thrilled to the feats of Warren Spahn, Eddie Matthews, Aaron, Joe Adcock, Del Crandall and Lou Burdette.

Major League baseball moved to within 100 miles of Eau Claire in 1961 when the Washington Senators became the Minnesota Twins and brought the American League to Metropolitan Stadium. Many city and area fans attend Twins games to watch such stars as Tony Oliva, Harmon Killebrew and Jim Kaat.

Milwaukee, deprived of major league ball by the Braves' departure to greener pastures in Atlanta in 1955, regained a franchise in 1970 from the bankrupt expansion club Seattle of the American League. The Brewers are finding no miracles this time in building a outstanding club or in attracting fans.

By 1960, pro baseball was in trouble here. Television had come, participation sports like golf and boating were winning spectators from the baseball parks, and pro football was making inroads on baseball's national popularity. Declining attendance forced Eau Claire to abandon its professional club after the 1961 season.

Lots of Baseball

Still, more baseball is played in Eau Claire than ever before. Boys baseball growth has been a major development of the past two decades. Little League started in 1952. Babe Ruth League followed, and Legion and high school baseball flourish.

Even in a pro club, Eau Claire was never without its own city team. From the Giants of 1918, to the Moose of 1924, to the Gillette Tires of the 1930's, to the Conoco Oilers of the 1950's, to Twin City Sports of the 1960's, there's been a team for city players.

Now, Eau Claire has the Cavaliers, organized along the lines of a pro club, playing a heavy schedule, and including top-notch city and area players. They are battling to bring fans back to the park with games against the best opposition available in a two-state area.